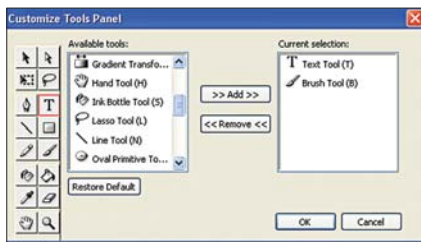




Illustrations Harsho Mohan Chatteraj

visible together. Adobe's products are notorious for having tools with sub-tools hidden in them. These can be accessed by holding down the left-click on a particular tool in the toolbar. These tools usually have a small tag on the



Flash CS3 toolbars can be modified to suite your style of working

right-bottom of the icon as an indicator.

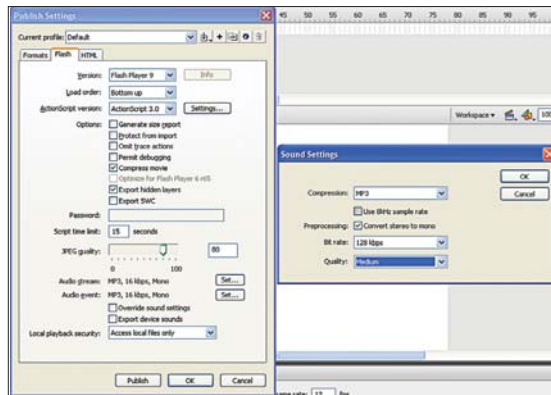
Adobe Flash CS3 allows you to add custom sub-tools to any existing tool. Just click on **Edit > Edit Tools Panel** and select the tool that you want to add the sub-tool to. Choose one from the list of available tools and click **Add** and then click **OK** when done. You can also remove sub-tools that may have come by default with Flash CS3 if you want to.

Onion Mode

The Onion mode in Flash is kind of like using the transparent sheet paper used by animators before computers came along. It allows you to get a reference of previous frames so as to be able to plot changes in the frames accurately. The Onion mode can be enabled by clicking on the **Onion Skin** button at the bottom of the timeline window. If you just want the outlines of the objects to be shown, then click on the **Onion Skin Outlines** button which is to the right of the **Onion Skin** button.

Tweak Compression Settings

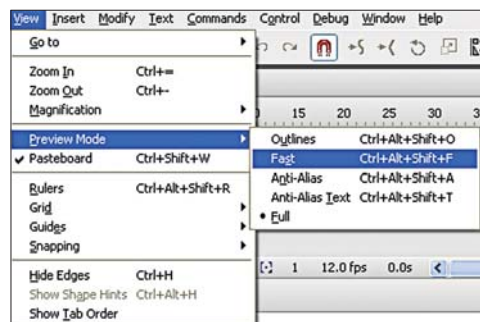
While working on Flash, you can import objects that weren't designed in Flash, such as images or videos. This can add to file sizes in Flash animations though. You can access compression settings by going to **File > Publish Settings > Flash**. You can modify the JPEG quality and the audio quality here. Other ways of getting smaller Flash file sizes is to set fairly low frame rates if your animation has no fast motions.



Compression settings for audio and images can be modified as per the needs

Better Performance

The preview feature will tell you how the project is coming along. Depending on the number of objects and layers, the performance of the preview can suffer and you might get really low frame rates. Flash gives you



Quality can be sacrificed for better performance during previews

the option to choose the quality of the preview too. Go to **View > Preview Mode** and choose from one of the modes listed there.

Quick Hide Toolbars

Like every other advanced graphics designing tool, Flash CS3 too has toolbars which eat up a lot of valuable workspace. Depending on the resolution of your monitor, you might end up with very little working space.

To get more space you can disable the toolbars by pressing [F4]. Pressing [F4] again will bring back the toolbars. The CS3 family of products also have toolbars that can be made more compact by clicking on the arrows at the title of each toolbar.

The Pen Tool

You might think that any freehand drawings done using the Pencil or Brush tool can't be edited easily. Flash is much more flexible than that. Clicking the pen tool displays the path for the freehand drawing and you can in fact add, remove and move control points in it. When you use the Eraser, new control points are automatically created to form a new modified shape.

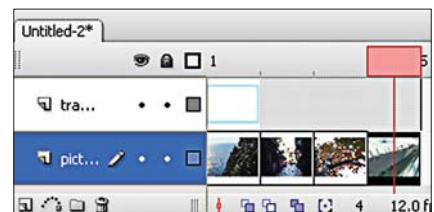
Animations And Keyframes

Animations in 3D or 2D are made up of a sequence of keyframes, each with objects in them. Flash, like other animation packages, works in the same manner,

and creating animations means you need to create keyframes wherever there's some kind of significant change made. To create a keyframe, right-click in the time line and click on **Insert keyframe**.

Making Better Use Of The Timeline Window

The timeline plays an important part in helping you keep track of everything going on in an animation. It allows you to jump to different positions and make changes to the animation. It looks rather simple but there are different faces to it. Click on the right top icon of the timeline window. Here, you can change the position of the window and the size of its contents. The most useful feature is evident when you choose the **Preview** mode. The timeline window now shows a frame-by-frame preview instead of just keyframes.



The timeline window is more versatile than one thinks